

5.2 Differences in water quality

Water quality can be affected by many everyday activities. When people defecate near rivers or streams, harmful bacteria and waste can enter the water. This is common in overpopulated cities or under-developed places. Agricultural areas also often add fertilisers, pesticides and animal waste to waterways through runoff, especially after rain. In towns and cities, development creates hard surfaces that wash oil, rubbish and chemicals into drains and creeks. In some places, people also wash themselves, clothes or dishes directly in rivers, adding soap, dirt and contaminants.

These impacts reduce water quality, making the water unsafe to drink and affecting ecosystems. Despite this, some communities must still use polluted water for cooking, washing, and even drinking when no safer source is available. This can lead to illness, the spread of disease, and long-term health problems. Students can annotate the cartoon to show where these issues occur and the consequences they create.

Activity: Annotate this cartoon to explain the ways different human activities affect water quality.



Activity 2: Create a cartoon that explains how ONE of the human activities mentioned affects water quality; including why it occurs and the different social, economic or environmental impacts of it.